

Amazon Website Usability Evaluation Using Nielsen's 10 Heuristics

1. Visibility of System Status

Amazon consistently provides feedback through loading indicators, order confirmations, and progress bars. However, when trying to file a complaint, system status is less visible. There are no clear signals that guide users toward the “complaint” pathway, making it easy to feel lost.

2. Match Between System and the Real World

Language such as “Help & Customer Service” matches user expectations. However, the term “partner company” is not clearly represented. Instead, Amazon uses terms like “third-party sellers” or “marketplace merchants,” which may confuse users unfamiliar with Amazon’s terminology.

3. User Control and Freedom

Navigation menus and back buttons make it simple to return to the homepage or previous screens. However, when moving deeper into the Help Center, users often need to retrace steps manually, as there are limited shortcuts to undo or jump directly to relevant complaint instructions.

4. Consistency and Standards

Amazon maintains visual consistency across its pages with standard icons, layouts, and menu structures. The main inconsistency lies in terminology—“partner companies,” “sellers,” and “merchants” may all refer to the same entities, creating cognitive friction.

5. Error Prevention

Amazon prevents most technical errors by confirming actions (such as canceling an order). However, it does little to prevent navigation errors. Users can easily end up in irrelevant help topics and waste time because complaint resources are hidden under vague categories.

6. Recognition Rather Than Recall

Menus and navigation bars provide recognizable options, but finding complaint instructions requires users to *remember* that “partner company” complaints are categorized under “third-party sellers.” This forces recall instead of relying on visible recognition.

7. Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

For advanced users, the search bar makes Amazon highly efficient. Without search, efficiency drops significantly. Users must browse through long menus and multiple pages to find relevant complaint instructions, making the process cumbersome.

8. Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Amazon's interface is visually crowded, filled with promotions, product recommendations, and dense lists of links. The Help section is particularly text-heavy, which detracts from clarity. Minimalism is sacrificed for comprehensiveness, overwhelming new users.

9. Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages on Amazon are generally clear. However, when searching for complaint information, users may encounter dead ends or irrelevant FAQs with little direction on how to "recover" and continue toward the correct resource.

10. Help and Documentation

Amazon offers extensive documentation through its Help Center. However, these documents are buried under multiple categories, requiring patience and persistence to locate. Instructions for filing complaints exist but are not easy to access without using search.

Amazon's site is powerful and feature-rich but not intuitive for the specific task of filing a complaint about a partner company. Without the search bar, users face a frustrating experience navigating vague menus and buried help documentation.